Psychological Assessment: Evidence, Validity, and Responsible Use

PSYCHOMETRICIAN · psychological-assessment · BoardPrep lesson v1

Official examination scope

PRC’s Psychologists and Psychometricians TOS is the examination-scope reference currently registered in this repository; currentness must be checked on the PRC board page before an exam. AERA/APA/NCME’s 2014 Standards remain versioned and the sponsors have begun revision work. This lesson is educational and not an individual test-interpretation or clinical recommendation.

Learning objectives

- Distinguish reliability evidence from validity evidence.
- Explain a standard error of measurement in a hypothetical score example.
- Select an assessment method in relation to purpose, population, context, and fairness.

1. Construct, purpose, and validity evidence

Start an assessment with the intended purpose and the construct or decision it is meant to inform. Validity concerns the evidence and theory supporting a particular interpretation and use of scores; it is not a permanent stamp attached to a test for every setting. Review content representation, response processes, internal structure, relationships with other variables, and consequences as relevant to the inference. A narrow sample of a broad trait can yield consistent scores while still leaving the intended construct underrepresented. State what the instrument can and cannot support.

2. Reliability, measurement error, and precision

Reliability describes consistency under specified conditions, such as internal consistency, inter-rater agreement, or test–retest stability. It does not establish that a test measures the intended construct. Under classical test theory, a simplified standard error of measurement is SEM = SD × (1 - r), where SD and reliability estimate r are appropriate to the same score interpretation. An SEM communicates expected score imprecision under the model; it is not a precise prediction for an individual’s true score. Report the reliability method, population, and context.

3. Select, administer, and interpret within scope

Choose measures whose evidence fits the referral question, language, age, accessibility needs, population, and decision stakes. Standardized administration supports comparability, while accommodations may be needed to reduce construct-irrelevant barriers; document changes and interpret their effects. Review norms, scoring, confidence or uncertainty, and the limits of the reference group before comparing a person with others. Combine test results with interviews, records, observations, and relevant contextual evidence rather than treating one score as a complete description of a person.

4. Ethics, fairness, and communication

Responsible assessment protects confidentiality, informed participation, test security, competence boundaries, and fair interpretation. Consider whether language, disability, culture, access, or testing conditions affect the inference. Explain findings in accessible terms, identify uncertainty, and make recommendations only within one’s competence and the instrument’s evidence. Legal scope in the Philippines is governed by the Psychology Act and current professional rules; standards from AERA, APA, and NCME are professional guidance, not Philippine statutes. Refer a question outside scope to the appropriate qualified professional.

Separate consistency from validity

Question: A stable trait is measured twice with the same test and the correlation is .88, but the test covers only one narrow part of the trait. What is best supported?
1. A high test–retest association supports temporal consistency under the sampled conditions.
2. Compare the test content with the full intended construct.
3. Do not infer broad validity from a reliability coefficient alone.
Answer: The test shows strong temporal reliability, while broader validity still needs evidence.
Check: Validity evidence must match the intended interpretation and use.

Common misconceptions

- A high reliability coefficient proves a measure is valid.
- A standard error of measurement is a guaranteed individual interval.
- A test result alone is a complete clinical or professional judgment.

Practice patterns

- Name the interpretation and decision before reviewing the score.
- Check population, method, and context for every coefficient.
- Communicate limits, uncertainty, and referral needs.

Official scope references

Official scope: Enhanced Tables of Specifications for the Psychologists and Psychometricians Licensure Examinations — Professional Regulation Commission; Professional Regulatory Board of Psychology — https://prc.gov.ph/Pages/PRBv4/Psychology.htm

Instructional references

Instructional reference: APA Guidelines for Psychological Assessment and Evaluation — American Psychological Association — https://www.apa.org/about/policy/guidelines-psychological-assessment-evaluation.pdf
Instructional reference: Standards for Educational and Psychological Testing — AERA, APA, and NCME — https://www.apa.org/science/programs/testing/standards
Instructional reference: Psychology 2e — OpenStax, Rice University — https://openstax.org/details/books/psychology-2e
Instructional reference: Introductory Statistics 2e — OpenStax; Illowsky and Dean — https://openstax.org/books/introductory-statistics-2e/pages/index
Instructional reference: Republic Act No. 10029, Philippine Psychology Act of 2009 — Republic of the Philippines; Lawphil text — https://lawphil.net/statutes/repacts/ra2010/ra_10029_2010.html

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